

post on message boards, make friend lists and join discussions with fellow gamers. Xbox Live marketplace was also launched that let users download applications, games and other promotional content straight to their consoles. Microsoft successfully turned console gaming into a more social experience.

Following Nintendo Wii's motion controller, Microsoft decided to jump onto the bandwagon too. Named the Kinect and launched in 2010, it was an add-on motion sensing camera that perceives depth and motion. It helped broaden the Xbox audience to include more casual gamers and helped boost the sales of the device.

PlayStation 3

Sony's last 2 consoles had been successful breaking and setting all sales records. The 3rd installment did similarly well. Announced at the 2005 E3, the console was released in November 2006 in Japan and North America followed by Europe and Australia a couple of months later.

Equipped with the latest tech and hardware of the time, it was the first console to come with a Blu-ray Disc drive. Sony also launched its own online social gaming platform called the PlayStation Network to compete with Xbox Live.

PS3 was off to a slow start in the beginning, partially because of lack of game titles. The complex architecture of the console was blamed by the game developers for delay in release of already announced titles. It was some time before Sony realized this and came out with software development kits that made developing games for the console easier.

The PS3 featured such impressive hardware that when the United States Air Force Research Laboratory started planning to build its own supercomputer, it ditched traditional hardware in favor of PlayStations. They connected 1760 PS3s together to build the 33rd most powerful supercomputer in the world at a lesser cost than what was traditionally possible (meanwhile, you are free to imagine the glorious gameplay such a setup can achieve for you).

Sony also launched PlayStation Move, a handheld motion controller, in September 2010 to compete with Nintendo Wii and Xbox's Kinect.

Nintendo Wii

Instead of fighting on the same old turf with the PS and Xbox, Nintendo tried to do something different. It shifted its focus from hardcore gamers and